



Discussion Guide: Hillary McBride

Body and Spirit: Why We Are Both and Why That Matters

Reflect

- In her opening story, Hillary asks, "If we are the hands and feet of God, then why is it that we so often think of our bodies as bad?" Have you ever struggled to view your body in a positive way? What did that look like and how did it affect you?
- Western philosophy has often affirmed that the body is inferior to the mind or spirit. Have you ever heard a similar message from your faith community? If so, describe what you were taught and how it came to shape your view of body and spirit.
- In our society, we are told what emotions we should and should not have: boys don't cry, anger doesn't look good on a woman, fear is the opposite of faith. What other messages have you received about which emotions are allowed? What potential problems come with denying the emotions our bodies feel?

Respond

- In discussing the neurobiology of the vagus nerve, Hillary refers to "the hidden wisdom written into our DNA." Describe a situation in which your body sensed something even before your mind had fully processed what was happening. What did this feel like and how did it help you respond to the situation?
- Hillary suggests that there is a connection between being aware of our emotions and our ability to be empathetic and respond to injustice. How are emotions, empathy, and justice related? In what ways are the "-isms" we encounter (sexism, racism, ableism, etc.) related to a devaluing of certain types of bodies?
- Consider the messages society gives us about topics such as food, sex, aging, and disabilities. How are these messages rooted in negative views of the body? How would you offer an alternative perspective based on Hillary's talk?

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